ceremony, of the Great Buddha at the ancient Japanese capital of Nara in 752 CE .

According to the Japanese chronicles, the Shoku Nihongi, Bodhisena (704–760 CE) was born in Madurai and travelled to Wutaishan in China on pilgrimage. He had dreamt that he would encounter a living incarnation of Maitreya, the future Buddha, there (this narrative illustrates how China had itself become a place of Buddhist pilgrimage, so much so that even Indian monks and pilgrims were attracted to its sacred places. One such sacred centre was Wutaishan which, as we saw in the previous chapter, was dedicated to the Bodhisattva Manjusri). While in China, he met a Japanese diplomatic mission led by Tajihu no Hironari, with whom he travelled back to Japan after visiting the Khmer and Champa kingdoms in what is now Cambodia and Vietnam, respectively. He arrived in Osaka in 736 CE and was received with great respect by the Japanese emperor, who later invited him to conduct the consecration ceremony of the Great Buddha image at the Todaiji temple in the capital, Nara. The rituals and the music used by Bodhisena are still preserved by the royal court in Japan. Bodhisena spent the rest of his years at the Daianji temple at Nara. He died in Japan.

Interestingly, the Sinicized brand of Buddhism did not take root in Central Asia which, by the eighth century, had been invaded and occupied by Arabs professing the Islamic faith. The new faith and its militant adherents conceded no space to an ancient religion whose worship of images was considered an abomination. In Central Asia, Chinese culture would run up against a new belief system and culture that rejected any Chinese claim to inherent superiority; and Central Asia did not aspire to become part of a Sinic world either. For the Han Chinese centred in the northern riverine basins of the Yellow River and the Yangzi, there were greener pastures to the south and east.

It was during the second century BCE that China, under the Han dynasty, expanded into the southern regions comprising present-day Guangdong, Guangxi and northern Vietnam. This large area, inhabited by local ethnic tribes, was incorporated into the Han empire and came to be known as Lingnan, or ‘South of the Mountains’. These mountains comprised a cluster